given our population, could see nearly 1.3 million cases a day," warns Dr V.K. Paul, member, NITI Aayog. "We need to watch the situation closely. It is important to focus on preventing a third wave." Other experts are hopeful a wave may not come at all. "Let us wait two more weeks and see if the numbers continue to increase. At the same time, we must double down on Covid precautions and get our hospitals ready," says Dr Rahul Pandit, director of critical care medicine and ICU at Fortis Mulund, Mumbai.

A lockdown should be the last option, experts say. "You don't need extensive lockdowns to live with Covid. The 'test-trace-treat-vaccinate' strategy is far more advanced today than a year ago. We should use these tools to our advantage," says noted virologist Dr Gagandeep Kang. Indeed, current guidelines ask states to impose lockdowns only when the test positivity rate is higher than 10 per cent or hospital bed occupancy crosses 40 per cent. Strategic measures should be implemented wherever there is indication of a spread. For instance, Mumbai's R-value is already over 1. While the city is not in lockdown, steps have been taken to reduce public contact, such as compulsory wearing of masks in schools and limited hours. Maharashtra also has a night curfew and malls and cinemas have been closed.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on December 25, too stressed on Covid-appropriate behaviour, particularly the wearing of masks. "One needs to wear a three-ply or an N95 mask. Single-layer cotton or cloth masks are not going to help," says Dr Ankita Baidya, a Delhi-based infectious diseases specialist.

VACCINE IS THE WEAPON

Experts are hopeful that vaccines will help reduce both the spread and severity of Covid disease this time. Eight Covid-19 vaccines have got emergency use authorisation from India's drug regulator —Covishield, Covaxin, ZyCoV-D, Sputnik V, Moderna, Johnson & Johnson, Corbevax and Covovax. Around 89 per cent of individuals above the age of 18 in the country have received a single dose of vaccine and 61 per cent have been fully vaccinated.

However, there are signs that two dose vaccines won't be enough to stop Omicron. Over 90 per cent of the Omicron cases in India were fully vaccinated, 3 per cent had taken booster shots abroad and another 2 per cent were partially vaccinated. A study by London's Imperial College says protection against severe disease caused by Omicron was a paltry 20 per cent after two doses of Covishield (taken by roughly 88 per cent of Indians vaccinated so far), and protection against death only 30 per cent. A booster shot improved protection against severe disease to 80 per cent and against death to 88 per cent. "A booster shot may provide 70-75 per cent protection against symptomatic infection," notes Dr Kang.

The Indian government has announced booster shots from January 10 for fully vaccinated healthcare and frontline workers as well as people above the age of 60 with co-morbidities. For the latter, the shot will be given on doctor's advice and can be taken only nine months after the second dose. Children in the age group of 15 to 18 will be eligible for a Covaxin jab from January 3. "Vaccinating children will ensure they do not pass on the illness to family members and would act as an added protection against Omicron," says Dr Naresh Trehan, chairman & MD, Medanta Hospital, Gurugram.

It is unclear, though, which vaccine can be taken as a booster. The Com-COV2 study in the UK found people had a better immune response when they received a first dose of AstraZeneca or Pfizer-BioNTech shots followed by Moderna nine weeks later. Deliberations are on within the MoHFW that the recently approved Covovax vaccine, to be produced by the Serum Institute of India, could be a contender for the third dose for those who have taken Covishield. And that Covishield itself could become a booster for those who took Covaxin. A decision is pending. "We are awaiting more data on the best practices for a third shot. We need a vaccine that can be scaled up for a booster shot," says an MoHFW official, requesting anonymity.

In the best case scenario, Omicron itself could end up providing natural immunity to many. "Data suggests Omicron is like a live weakened virus. If it only causes mild illness then it will be a booster for the vaccination and a vaccine dose for others," says Dr Budhiraja.

Treatment preparations for a surge are underway even as containment steps are being taken. India has an estimated 1,810,083 isolation beds, 494,314 oxygen beds, 139,300 ICU beds and 18,836

WHY WE NEED A BOOSTER

↘ TWO-DOSE VACCINES WON'T PREVENT INFECTION
91% of the total Omicron cases in India were fully vaccinated, 3% had taken booster shots abroad; 2% of the patients were partially vaccinated.



↘ TWO DOSES MIGHT NOT HELP PREVENT DEATH
An Imperial College study showed that after two doses of Covishield (taken by roughly 88% of Indians who have been vaccinated so far), protection against severe disease caused by Omicron was 20% and protection against death 30%.

↘ HOW A BOOSTER HELPS
According to the study, protection against severe disease after a booster shot goes up to 80% and against death to 88%. Globally, 19.4% people in the US have taken a booster shot, 36% in Germany, 40% in the UK, and 11% in Brazil.

